

Thirty Lessons from Scroll Reader

What an audio-first library of the same classics gets right, what Ochorus already does better, and five things to act on

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What Scroll Reader is

A free library of 172 public-domain Christian audiobooks by 111 authors — Bounds, Miller, Murray, Müller, Bunyan, Brooks, Watson, Flavel, Taylor, Paton, Carmichael — narrated in-house and distributed on the site, YouTube and Spotify. English only, no biographies, no plans, client-rendered. The overlap with the Ochorus shelf is large, which makes it a useful mirror: same books, opposite bet. They bet on the ear; we bet on the page and the world's languages.

Four big takeaways

1 Audio is the whole product, not a feature

Every book page opens on a player: chapters, 15-second skips, speed, sleep timer, download and a synced transcript. Ochorus has a fine reader with text-to-speech attached. The lesson is that listening deserves first-class surfaces — a Listen page, a mini-player, a Downloads list — not a button inside the reader.

2 One text, packaged three ways

Each book feeds the library, a community quote feed and an “Articles & Excerpts” blog of chapters retitled with magazine headlines (“The Christmas Pudding That Made an Atheist Believe” is a Mildred Cable chapter). Ochorus already has quotes and Articles; the gap is headline craft and volume.

3 Everything works signed out

Favorites, bookmarks, quotes, history and preferences live on the device under a plain “saved to your device — no account needed”. Sign-in only unlocks cross-device stats. The free promise is stated, not implied: “172 audiobooks — all free, forever. No subscription needed.”

4 Missionary biography is the lead genre

Roughly a third of the shelf is biography, and the Region topics — China, India, Congo, Sierra Leone, Nepal, Mongolia — do heavy lifting on the home page. That validates the African voices push and argues for Region as a browsing dimension of its own.

THE MIRROR

Where they are strong — listening, packaging, plain promises — Ochorus is adequate. Where Ochorus is strong — languages, biographies, plans, typography, prerendering — they are absent. Borrow the first list; do not trade away the second.

The thirty lessons, part one

Discovery and the listening surface. Each carries a status against the current Ochorus build.

HAVE Ochorus does this already

PARTIAL a version exists, theirs goes further

NEW nothing comparable yet

DISCOVERY AND BROWSING

- 1 **Duration on every card** **HAVE** “4h 16m” tells the listener what they are committing to before they tap. Ochorus cards show reading time; keep it, and add it to sermon and plan cards where it is missing.
- 2 **Continue Listening first** **PARTIAL** A returning visitor sees a Continue strip above everything else, with the cover and chapter. Ochorus does this for reading; the listen position should resume the same way.
- 3 **Recent Additions as the lead row** **NEW** First row on the home page, with a “Browse all, newest first” link. Ochorus adds works weekly and only exposes that in the RSS feed and admin.
- 4 **Trending this week** **NEW** A row driven by real play counts. Ochorus has progress data to do the same for “most read this week”.
- 5 **Topics in parent groups** **NEW** 53 topics sit under eight groups — Spiritual Disciplines, Missions, Doctrine, Region — each chip carrying a count. Ochorus topics are one flat list.
- 6 **Region as a topic dimension** **NEW** Africa, China, India, Japan and Mongolia each get a page. Ochorus has the content for Africa, Uganda and Tanzania pages already.
- 7 **Author list with dates and counts** **PARTIAL** Life dates, a book count, an A-to-Z rail and three sort orders (name, most books, most listened), led by a Prolific Authors row.
- 8 **A century timeline of authors** **PARTIAL** The Authors page links a Church History Timeline. Theirs is broken; Ochorus already has an era strip on Biographies and spans Ignatius to Müller. Promote it.
- 9 **More like this, ten deep** **PARTIAL** Related titles on every book page with a Load More. Ochorus shows related works; the list is short.
- 10 **Category plus hashtag topics** **HAVE** One category and clickable #topics on the book page, both leading to browse pages.

READING AND LISTENING

- 11 **Tap a line to seek** **PARTIAL** Read Along shows the transcript; tap any line and the audio jumps there. Ochorus text-to-speech follows the spoken paragraph; tapping a paragraph should start speech from it.
- 12 **Long-press to quote** **PARTIAL** Quote capture lives inside the transcript, not on a separate page. A long-press on any line opens “Save quote from here”.
- 13 **Sleep timer, skip interval, chapter buttons** **PARTIAL** All present and all configurable; the skip interval is a setting (5 to 60 s). Ochorus has the sleep timer; add the skips and a chapter step.
- 14 **A visible Download** **PARTIAL** A Download button per book and a Downloads page make the offline promise concrete. Ochorus caches through the service worker but never says so.
- 15 **Persistent mini-player** **PARTIAL** On mobile the player pins above the tab bar and survives navigation. Ochorus has a listen bar inside the reader only.
- 16 **Live font-size preview** **HAVE** The Read Along font setting shows a sample quote at the chosen size. Ochorus’ Aa panel previews already; extend it to the listen transcript.

The thirty lessons, part two

Quotes, content packaging and the small trust signals.

HAVE Ochorus does this already

PARTIAL a version exists, theirs goes further

NEW nothing comparable yet

QUOTES AND SHARING

- 17 **Community quotes with counts** **PARTIAL** The home page shows quotes with save and share counts. Ochorus has curated author quote pages; a community feed with reactions is the next step.
- 18 **Configurable quote images** **PARTIAL** Include a link back, include the title, wrap in quotation marks. Ochorus' share card is fixed; three toggles would cover most asks.
- 19 **An "example output" preview** **NEW** Under the quote settings sits a rendered example, so people see the share before they share.
- 20 **My Data, listed** **NEW** A section that names what you own — favorites, bookmarks, saved quotes, stats — with a note that it stays on the device.

CONTENT STRATEGY

- 21 **Blurbs written as invitations** **NEW** Every page opens with a one-paragraph hook, then a longer About behind Read more. Ochorus descriptions are catalogue copy.
- 22 **Chapters retitled as articles** **PARTIAL** Their Articles are chapters with headlines. Ochorus Articles shipped this month; mine existing chapters the same way before writing new pieces.
- 23 **A "From the book" badge** **NEW** Articles drawn from a book carry a badge linking back to the chapter, so the article sells the book.
- 24 **Printed Books page** **NEW** Every title paired with where to buy a physical copy, ranked by popularity. Check affiliate terms; goodwill links are fine.
- 25 **Syndicate the audio** **NEW** "Available on YouTube and Spotify" on each book, linking back. Ochorus TTS audio could be published the same way once voices are good enough.
- 26 **Show the published year** **PARTIAL** "Published 1936" under the author. Ochorus has the field and emits it only in structured data; put it on the page.

PRODUCT AND TRUST

- 27 **Customisable tab bar and player** **NEW** Pick up to five mobile tabs and four player actions, drag to reorder. Ambitious; the memorable part is that the player row is user-chosen.
- 28 **Push for new books** **NEW** Opt-in push for new additions, with a clear "blocked by browser, tap the lock icon" when denied.
- 29 **Free, forever, said out loud** **PARTIAL** A banner that says free with no subscription, and a Donate link beside About. Ochorus says free in the tagline only.
- 30 **A useful 404** **NEW** The not-found page lists recent audiobooks and recent articles instead of a dead end.

What Ochorus already does better

Worth naming, so the borrowing does not become imitation.

STRENGTH	ON SCROLL READER
Multilingual	Scroll Reader is English only. Ochorus’ per-language editions and review badges have no equivalent.
Author biographies	Their author page is a name, an initial and a cover grid. Ochorus bio pages carry 1,500-word lives, dates and quotes.
Reading plans	Nothing comparable on Scroll Reader.
Prerendered pages	Book and author pages are client-rendered; a slug with an apostrophe, the About page and the timeline link all returned Not Found or a blank shell. Ochorus prerenders and gates fixtures in CI.
Designed covers	Their covers are AI paintings, attractive but uniform. Ochorus hand-made covers are frozen by rule.
Typography for reading	Their transcript is a utility panel. Ochorus is a reader first: drop caps, measure, margins.

Five to act on

Ordered by value per day of work. Each is one branch and one PR.

- 1

Recent Additions and Most Read rows on the home page

Two list endpoints ordered by created date and by reading events in the last seven days; two rows under Continue Reading. A day of work, and it makes weekly imports visible.
- 2

Tap-to-speak and long-press-to-quote in the reader

While speech is playing, tapping a paragraph restarts speech from it; a long-press opens the existing quote card pre-filled. Both hang off code that already exists in listen.svelte.ts and the share card.
- 3

Region as a topic group, and grouped topics

Add a group field to Topic (Discipline, Doctrine, Missions, Region, Life), render the topics page as grouped chips with counts. Region pages for Africa, Uganda and Tanzania land with the African voices work.
- 4

Article headlines mined from existing chapters

Pick twenty chapters with a story in them, give each a headline and a two-sentence hook, publish as Articles with a “From the book” link back. Content only; no code beyond the badge.
- 5

Say what is free and what is saved

A one-line “Free, forever, no subscription” on the home page, a visible Download on the book page, a My Data block in settings, and the published year on the book page. Copy and small components.

NOT TO COPY

The customisable tab bar, push notifications and the Printed Books page are real work for marginal return on a reading site. Note them; do not schedule them.